

Crucial Conversation Prep Worksheet

Scenario Example: A team member requests to change accounts due to dissatisfaction with the account, its complexity, or leadership. Transfers are rare and reserved for specific circumstances.



1. Lead with the Heart

Purpose: Approach this conversation with empathy and curiosity. A request to transfer is often a signal of frustration, being overwhelmed, or unmet expectations. The goal is to understand the concern, explore solutions within the current account, and reinforce that transfers are not the default solution.

Example Reflection: "I want to understand what's driving this request and explore how we can address those concerns here first, while being honest about how rarely transfers occur."

Prompts:

- How do I validate their experience without promising a transfer?
- How do I frame this as problem-solving, not avoidance?
- How do I reinforce accountability while remaining supportive?

Example Opening Line: "I want to understand what's behind your request and talk through whether we can address those concerns within your current account."

2. Define the Ideal Outcome

Example: "By the end of the conversation, the team member feels heard, understands why transfers are rare, and is open to addressing their concerns within the current account with support."

3. Define the Negative Outcome to Avoid

Example: “Avoid reinforcing the idea that discomfort leads to reassignment. Avoid appearing dismissive of their concerns. Avoid setting expectations that cannot be fulfilled.”

4. Gather the Facts

Example Notes:

- Specific concerns raised about the account, workload, or leadership.
- Performance history on the account (quality, productivity, attendance, coachability).
- Support already provided (coaching, nesting, shadowing, schedule adjustments).
- Whether challenges appear skill-based, effort-based, or situational.

5. Gain Buy-In After Presenting the Facts

Purpose: Invite the team member to reflect on their experience and participate in problem-solving, rather than positioning a transfer as the solution.

Sample Questions:

- What specifically feels most challenging about this account?

- Is it the work itself, the pace, or how support shows up?
 - What support do you feel would help you be successful here?
 - If those supports were in place, would you be open to continuing on this account?
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6. Conversation Plan (Outline)

1. Open with empathy and intent.

“I appreciate you being honest about how you’re feeling. Let’s talk through what’s driving this request.”

2. Acknowledge concerns as valid feedback.

“Concerns about an account or leadership are important feedback, and I want to understand them fully.”

3. Present expectations and context.

“Our preference is always to resolve concerns within the account. Transfers are rare because they can have significant operational and performance impacts.”

4. Gain buy-in after presenting the facts.

“Given that context, let’s explore what would need to change for you to be successful here.”

5. Collaborate on next steps.

“We can work on targeted coaching, added support, or leadership alignment to address what’s not working.”

6. Reaffirm role and transparency.

"I don't approve transfers, but I do escalate recommendations when appropriate. My responsibility is to ensure we've explored all options first."



7. Reflection (After the Meeting)

- Did I avoid over-promising or positioning a transfer as likely?
- Did I treat their concerns as valid feedback?
- Did I reinforce accountability and problem-solving?
- Did I clearly explain my role in the process?
- What follow-up actions are needed?
